OVERPLAY + NASCAR

Turning Spectators Into Players

ROLE: Senior Product Designer
PROJECT: Overplay — NASCAR Interactive Gaming Experience
SCOPE: Product Strategy · UX Research · Experience Design · Interaction Design · Design Systems
CONTEXT: 2025–2026 · Sports Entertainment · Interactive Gaming

OVERVIEW

Overplay partnered with NASCAR teams, including Front Row Motorsports and ThorSport Racing, to extend its reach beyond traditional gaming audiences.

The opportunity was to turn sponsorship visibility into meaningful product engagement.
I led product experience design focused on connecting NASCAR's racing culture with interactive gameplay, creating experiences that encouraged fans to move beyond watching and actively participate in the platform.

The work connected product strategy, user experience, competitive mechanics, and event-based experiences to create a more engaging relationship between fans and the sport.

THE CHALLENGE

Overplay needed to reach audiences beyond traditional gaming communities. NASCAR offered access to a passionate sports audience, but brand exposure alone would not create sustained product engagement.

The real challenge was to connect the excitement of racing with an interactive experience that gave fans a reason to participate, compete, and return.

THREE KEY DESIGN CHALLENGES

01 — Translating Racing Culture into Gameplay

Move beyond using NASCAR as a visual branding layer. Find ways to translate the sport's drivers, competition, and racing culture into meaningful gameplay experiences.

02 — Designing for Participation and Retention

Create accessible entry points for first-time users while introducing competitive mechanics that encouraged replay, progression, and continued engagement.

03 — Balancing Brand and Product Constraints

Work within strict NASCAR branding and sponsorship guidelines, tight event-driven production timelines, and the need for consistency across physical and digital touchpoints.

CORE UX QUESTION

How might we transform the energy of NASCAR into an interactive product experience that motivates fans to move from watching the sport to actively participating in it?

PRODUCT STRATEGY

From sponsorship to interactive fan experiences

The strategic decision was to make NASCAR part of the gameplay itself, rather than treating it as a branding exercise.

01 — RESEARCH & AI-ASSISTED EXPLORATION
Use AI-assisted research and ideation to explore fan engagement opportunities, investigate interaction concepts, and generate alternative ways to connect NASCAR culture with Overplay's gaming model.
Explore how driver recognition, racing culture, competition, and event participation could become meaningful product interactions.

02 — TRANSLATE INSIGHTS INTO GAMEPLAY
Turn the strongest opportunities into five experience directions:

- Driver-based gameplay: Connect fans with recognizable drivers.
- Racing-themed templates: Bring the excitement and identity of racing into gameplay.
- Event-driven competitions: Give fans reasons to participate around race events.
- Leaderboards and performance: Introduce competition, comparison, and progression.
- Connected experiences: Maintain consistency across physical activations and digital interactions.
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03 — DESIGN FOR REPEAT ENGAGEMENT
Prioritize mechanics that extend beyond a single interaction, encouraging fans to replay, compete, and return for new event-based experiences.

STRATEGIC DESIGN DECISION
Rather than using NASCAR sponsorship simply to attract attention, embed the sport's identity and competitive culture into the product experience — turning brand affinity into active participation.

PRODUCT DESIGN & ENGAGEMENT MECHANICS

The strategy translated into a set of product mechanics designed to connect racing culture with the motivations that drive participation: competition, achievement, and progression.

01 — BUILD COMPETITIVE GAMEPLAY LOOPS
Designed gameplay experiences around racing themes, giving fans a reason to participate and compete rather than simply consume branded content.

02 — CREATE REASONS TO PLAY AGAIN
Introduced high-score challenges and repeatable interactions to encourage replay and sustained participation.

03 — REDUCE FIRST-TIME FRICTION
Simplified entry into the gameplay experience, helping new users understand how to participate without unnecessary complexity.

04 — CONNECT INTERACTIONS TO USER MOTIVATION
Aligned gameplay mechanics with competition and progression, using scores, rankings, and performance feedback to reinforce engagement.

05 — DESIGN FOR REPEATABLE EXECUTION
Created scalable experience templates that supported ongoing event-based content and consistent product experiences across activations.

DESIGN RATIONALE
Every interaction needed a purpose: make participation accessible, give users a reason to compete, and create motivation to return.


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FOLLOW
87 K
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48.6 K
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GET IT ON Google Play
Download on the App Store
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Awesome!
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MEASURABLE IMPACT

+20%

Increase in games played
(300,000 → 360,000)

+7%

Increase in creator uploads
(2,500 → 2,675)

HIGHER REPLAY FREQUENCY
Racing competitions generated higher replay frequency compared with baseline templates, demonstrating the potential of event-driven competitive experiences to encourage repeat engagement.

EXPANDED BRAND EXPOSURE
National press coverage and increased brand visibility extended Overplay's reach beyond traditional gaming audiences.

PRODUCT DESIGN TAKEAWAY
When a brand partnership becomes part of the product experience, it can create more meaningful opportunities for participation, competition, and content creation.

OUTCOMES & REFLECTION

01 — DESIGN AROUND USER MOTIVATION

Understanding what drives an audience to participate is essential. In this case, competition, achievement, and progression provided the foundation for translating racing culture into interactive experiences.

02 — USE AI TO EXPLORE, NOT REPLACE JUDGMENT

AI-assisted research and ideation expanded the range of concepts and possibilities considered during the design process. Product strategy and UX judgment were essential to evaluating those directions and translating them into meaningful experiences.

03 — CONNECT EXPERIENCE DESIGN TO BUSINESS OUTCOMES

Product experiences should be designed with measurable objectives. Gameplay activity, creator participation, and replay behavior provided indicators of how the experience performed.

04 — DESIGN FOR SCALE AND CONTINUITY

Event-based partnerships create opportunities beyond individual activations. Scalable experience templates help maintain consistency while supporting new content and engagement opportunities.

FINAL REFLECTION

The strongest product experiences connect audience motivation, thoughtful UX decisions, and business objectives. AI can accelerate exploration, but meaningful product outcomes depend on how well those insights are translated into the experience.